

UNIT 2 · LESSON 5

The Friend Test

40 min · December Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students deepen their Compassionate Witness practice through the Friend Test framework and apply it to a situation where they have been treating themselves with less fairness than they would treat a friend.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: self-compassion as a regulation strategy · Social Awareness: applying empathy to the self
SCENARIO CARDS	Friend Test Scenario Pairs A & B — structured partner exchange
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "In Lesson 4, we learned the four-step accountability structure and introduced the Friend Test. Quick: what is the Friend Test question?" (student answers) "Today we practice it — with each other. This is the lightest lesson of Unit 2. Use it to consolidate everything you've built."

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 6–8 · MIDDLE / JUNIOR HIGH**Goal 1 — Self-Awareness & Self-Management****1A.3a** Analyze factors that create stress or that motivate successful performance.**1B.3a** Analyze how personal qualities influence choices and successes.*Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).***ANCHOR CHART · THE FRIEND TEST — SIDE-BY-SIDE SPEECH BUBBLES**Draw this on the board **before class**.**LEFT BUBBLE:** "What I would say to my best friend in this situation."**RIGHT BUBBLE:** "What I actually say to myself in this situation."Central question posted large: *"What is the gap between these two bubbles — and what does that gap tell you?"*Key message: *"The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself."***OPENING · 3 MINUTES**

"Think about your closest friend. If they came to you in a genuinely hard moment — they had just failed something, made a mistake, been hurt — how would you talk to them? Now: is that how you talk to yourself in the same situation? Today we look at that gap."

► **DIRECT INSTRUCTION**

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 3 · read aloud or in your own words

01 The Friend Test Foundation

5 MIN

"The Friend Test is simple and powerful. When your internal critic is speaking, ask: would I say this to my closest friend in the same situation? If the answer is no — the critic is not being fair. The Compassionate Witness says what you would say to the friend."

Point to both speech bubbles. *"The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself."*

02 Partner Practice

15 MIN

"Student choice — pick someone you are comfortable with. Each of you: identify one situation where you have been hard on yourself. Share only with your partner — not the class. Your partner responds as they would respond to a friend in the EXACT SAME situation. Then switch."

Allow 12 minutes for the full exchange.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE A student who cannot identify a single situation where they have been hard on themselves — who genuinely appears to have no access to this.

MAY SIGNAL May indicate either healthy self-compassion (genuine — worth noting positively) or significant emotional shutdown where self-critical patterns are not accessible to conscious reflection.

ACTION Do not press during partner work. In the journal step (Step 3), offer: "You can write about a situation where a friend was hard on themselves — and what you would say to them."

03 The Compassionate Witness Deepened

10 MIN

"Using what your partner just gave you — write a new Compassionate Witness statement about the current situation, using the Friend Test language: 'If my friend was going through this, I would say _____. So I am saying it to myself: _____.'"

Allow 5 minutes of private writing. This is the primary artifact.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE Before U2L6: notice who is unable to access any Compassionate Witness response — who genuinely cannot write a kinder internal sentence after the full Friend Test exercise.

MAY SIGNAL A student who cannot access the Compassionate Witness after L1, L4, and now L5 may have a deeply entrenched self-critical pattern. This is the most significant risk indicator for L6.

ACTION Raise with the counselor before U2L6 delivery — specifically flag this student as someone who may need additional support during the Script Analysis activity.

SCENARIO CARDS

FT PAIR A Sports Tryout · Jamie

Didn't make the team, quits gym, stops eating well. Apply the Friend Test — what would Jamie say to her best friend?

FT PAIR B The Social Rejection · Theo

Not invited to party, saw photos online, withdrew. High-frequency for this age group. Handle with care — do not ask if this resonates personally.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Students choose their own partners. Keep partner sharing light and optional. The journal is where the real work happens.

Grades 7–8: "Why is it so much easier to extend compassion to others than to ourselves? What does this asymmetry tell us about how we have been taught to think about self-care?"

EXIT TICKET

"One thing I am currently being harder on myself about than I would be on my best friend is _____. My Friend Test response to myself is _____."

Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Lightest lesson of Unit 2 in terms of emotional intensity — can function as a processing and consolidation session. Before U2L6: confirm counselor co-facilitation is set. Review your observations from L1–L5 for any students who may need extra support.

Students who cannot identify a Compassionate Witness response across L1, L4, and L5 are your highest-risk students for L6. Brief the counselor specifically on these students.

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today students practised the Friend Test — applying the same compassion to themselves that they naturally give to their friends. At home, when your child is being hard on themselves, try asking: "Would you say that to your best friend?" Then listen.

ANCHOR CHART · THE FRIEND TEST — SIDE-BY-SIDE SPEECH
BUBBLES

Build Specification

BEST FRIEND BUBBLE

What I would say to my best friend
Kind
Fair
Honest
Without punishment

SELF BUBBLE

What I actually say to myself
Often harsh
Often globalising
Often unfair
Would never say to a friend

Central question: *"What is the gap between these two bubbles — and what does that gap tell you?"*
"The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself."

POST : Before class. · **KEEP :** Unit 2 and Unit 3.

ANCHOR CHART · CLASSROOM DISPLAY — PRINT ON CARDSTOCK OR 11×17, POST AS THE LESSON INDICATES

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 3 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

The Friend Test

Unit 2

SELF-COMPASSION

TO MY BEST FRIEND

- What I would say to my best friend in this situation

TO MYSELF

- What I actually say to myself in this situation

The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself.

THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE FOUNDATION · CONFIDENTIAL — FOR DISTRICT REVIEW ONLY

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 3 · The Interior (6–8)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org